Part IV: Israel, the Nations, and the Commission

Chapter 20: Romans 9 — “not all who are from Israel are Israel”

Part III ended by putting the original question back on the table: Israel, the nations, and what the commission actually required of whom.

This Part answers it by working through the three chapters where Paul takes it up directly. And I want to say at the outset that I came to Romans 9 already knowing what it meant, which by now should be a warning sign to anyone reading this book carefully.

PAUL BEGINS WITH ANGUISH, NOT WITH A VERDICT

The first thing Romans 9 does is not doctrinal. Paul says he has great sorrow and unceasing anguish in his heart, and that he could wish himself accursed and cut off from Messiah for the sake of his kinsmen according to the flesh.

That is not the opening of a man announcing that a people has been set aside. Whatever Paul is about to argue, he is arguing it in grief, about his own family, and the grief is the reason the argument exists.

AND HE CALLS THEM ISRAELITES, IN THE PRESENT TENSE

> They **are** Israelites, and to them belong the adoption, the glory, the covenants, the giving of the law, the worship, and the promises (Romans 9:4)

The Greek is Ἰσραηλῖται (*Israēlitai*). Not *they used to be*. Not *until Messiah came*.

Paul is writing after the death, the resurrection, the ascension, Pentecost and the inclusion of Gentiles. And he calls his **unbelieving** ethnic kinsmen Israelites, and then piles honour on honour rather than speaking of their covenantal history with contempt — the patriarchs are theirs, and Messiah Himself comes from them according to the flesh.

> **FINDING — A BRAKE ON 9:6, ESTABLISHED FROM 9:4, TWO VERSES EARLIER**
>
> Whatever covenantal change Messiah brought, Paul has **not** reassigned the word so that unbelieving Jews can no longer hold it.
>
> Any reading of verse 6 that requires *Israel* to have been transferred away from them has to get past verse 4 first, and verse 4 is in the same breath. I had never noticed that, because I had always arrived at Romans 9 already looking for verse 6.

And a detail in the inventory that put back in front of me a question this book had already met. A well-attested Greek reading has **the covenants**, plural — διαθῆκαι (*diathēkai*) — while another textual tradition has the singular, ἡ διαθήκη (*hē diathēkē*). RVR1960 follows the singular with *el pacto*. The Spanish edition of this book flags the same variant at its Chapter 5, and I do not adjudicate it in either edition. Under the plural reading the inventory would name the Abrahamic, the Sinaitic, the Davidic and the new one promised through Jeremiah — the refinement from Chapter 13, a single covenantal story containing multiple covenants, in Paul's own grammar. But that refinement cannot rest on this verse while the variant is open, and it never did: Chapter 13 does not cite Romans 9:4 anywhere.

ONLY NOW DOES THE PROBLEM APPEAR

With that inventory in place, Paul states the difficulty, and it is worth stating precisely because almost every argument I have had about this chapter mislocates it.

Paul's immediate problem is **not** *who is the Church?* It is: **how can Yahweh's promises to Israel remain trustworthy when so many Israelites stand outside their messianic fulfilment?**

That is a question about the reliability of God, raised by a Jew, about Jews. Reading it as a question about ecclesiology is answering something Paul did not ask.

THE WORDPLAY, WHICH ENGLISH MOSTLY HIDES

> οὐ γὰρ πάντες οἱ ἐξ Ἰσραὴλ οὗτοι Ἰσραήλ
>
> Very literally: *for not all those from Israel — these are Israel* (Romans 9:6)

Paul uses *Israel* twice, deliberately. There is Israel₁, those who are **from** Israel, and Israel₂, those who constitute Israel in the sense relevant to the promise.

So the question is what distinguishes the second from the first. And this is exactly where I jumped too quickly for years.

PAUL ANSWERS WITH ISAAC, NOT WITH GENTILE CHRISTIANS

> and not all are children of Abraham because they are his offspring, but "Through Isaac shall your offspring be named" (Romans 9:7)

Who is being contrasted? **Ishmael and Isaac.** Both biologically Abraham's.

Verse 8's *children of the promise* sounds like something that could include Gentiles, and elsewhere Paul does connect Gentiles to the Abrahamic promise. But here his first example is not Jew against Gentile. It is one son of Abraham against another.

> **ISAAC AND ISHMAEL — WHAT THE FIRST DEMONSTRATION SHOWS**
>
> Paul's first demonstration **establishes** that biological descent from Abraham has never, by itself, determined the line through which the covenant promise proceeds.
>
> It does **not** establish that *Israel now means the Church*. That is a much larger claim, and Paul has not made it here. The distinction he draws in 9:7 runs *inside* Abraham's household, and importing a Jew/Gentile frame onto it is reading the conclusion back into the example.

That is considerably more precise than what I had been saying, and considerably less useful to the position I held when I arrived.

MALACHI, AND WHY THREE KINDS OF EVIDENCE CANNOT BE ONE KIND

Then Paul quotes Jacob loved, Esau hated — and this is where the chapter taught me something about method rather than about Israel.

> **The case the never-collapse rule exists for**
>
> I asked three different questions of the same quotation and got three different kinds of answer.
>
> *What does "Esau" mean?* That is a **lexical** question, and it yields nothing that solves Romans 9.
>
> *What is Paul's immediate context?* That is **contextual**, and it tells me he is discussing Israel and the reliability of Yahweh's promise.
>
> *Where did the quotation come from?* That is **intertextual**, and it is the one that changes things. Malachi 1:2-3 is not speaking about two indi-

> viduals deciding their eternal destinies. Malachi is speaking about **Edom** — a nation — and its territory. And behind Malachi stands Genesis 25:23, where Rebekah is told that **two nations** are in her womb.
>
> The intertextual evidence materially alters how much I am entitled to infer from Paul's words, and neither the lexical nor the contextual work would ever have produced it.
>
> If I had merged these three into an undifferentiated "evidence," the Edom and nations dimension would simply have been invisible. Not refuted — invisible. That is the specific loss the never-collapse rule exists to prevent, and this is the clearest case of it I have hit.

I want to be careful about what that does and does not buy. It does not establish that Romans 9 is *only* about nations and not about individuals; Paul is plainly applying the pattern to individuals standing outside the messianic fulfilment. It establishes that the quotation arrives carrying a corporate and territorial history that a reader working only from Paul's sentence would never suspect.

THEN PAUL CLOSES THE ESCAPE ROUTE I WANTED

Having found that, my instinct was to soften the passage into a statement purely about nations and roles, which would have made it much more comfortable.

Paul does not permit it. He goes on to Exodus 33:19 — *I will have mercy on whom I have mercy* — and then to Pharaoh, and then to the potter and the clay.

EXODUS 33:19, AFTER THE GOLDEN CALF

Exodus 33:19 is not spoken in a vacuum. **The golden calf has just happened.** Israel has broken the covenant almost immediately after receiving it, Moses is interceding, and the mercy formula is Yahweh's answer in that situation.

Which means the verse Paul reaches for to make his point about sovereign mercy is a verse in which **Israel itself survives only by mercy**. That is not a text about God choosing some people and rejecting others from outside. It is a text about a covenant people that had already forfeited its standing and was spared.

And the potter and the clay is not Paul's image either. It is Jeremiah's and Isaiah's, and in Jeremiah 18 the imagery is explicitly about Yahweh's authority over **the house of Israel**, with the outcome conditioned on that nation's response.

ROMANS 9'S PROPHETIC IMAGERY — THE BRAKE, IN BOTH DIRECTIONS

What **can** be established: Paul uses prophetic imagery whose scriptural background concerns Yahweh's sovereign authority over covenant peoples and nations, Israel in particular.

What **cannot** be established from that background alone: that the passage therefore carries no individual application. Showing that a determinist reading overreaches does not establish the corporate-only reading in its place — that would be the Anti-Replacement Principle again, and I have now caught myself at it enough times to expect it.

ONE VERIFICATION THAT CHANGED LESS THAN I HOPED

I did the grammatical work on Romans 9:22 and 23, because a great deal of argument rests on whether the two are parallel.

They are not parallel. Verse 23 has an active verb with God as its subject. Verse 22 has a participle that is morphologically ambiguous between middle and passive, and it names no agent.

That asymmetry is real and established. What it **means** is not. A middle voice would suggest the vessels fitted themselves; a passive would suggest they were fitted; and Greek perfect middle and passive forms are frequently identical, so the ambiguity may be a morphological accident rather than an authorial choice.

I am recording it at exactly that strength. It is a fact about the grammar that constrains confident readings on both sides, and it is not a conclusion.

AND THEN THE CHAPTER REFUSES TO STAY INSIDE ETHNIC ISRAEL

Having spent the chapter insisting that Paul is talking about Israel, I have to report where Paul goes next, because it cuts the other way.

He quotes Hosea — *those who were not my people I will call my people* — and applies it to the calling of Gentiles. Then he quotes Isaiah on a remnant of Israel being saved.

So both are in the chapter. The vocabulary of Israel's restoration is applied to Gentiles, and the hope held out for ethnic Israel is a remnant rather than a replacement. Neither half is an intrusion into the other.

OPEN QUESTION — HELD OPEN, AND IT WILL COST SOMETHING LATER

Paul quotes Hosea in a form closer to the Septuagint than to the Hebrew text, and this is not the only place in the New Testament where that happens.

For a method that says *go to the source languages*, that is a real complication rather than a curiosity: the apostles are quoting a **translation**, and building arguments on it. I am flagging it here, not resolving it, and it returns two chapters from now, where Paul turns out to match neither the Hebrew nor the Greek, and where James's use of Amos 9 at the Jerusalem Council has to be faced.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Paul opens in anguish over his own kinsmen and calls them Israelites in the present tense, after Pentecost, which brakes any reading of 9:6 that transfers the word away from them. His first demonstration is Ishmael against Isaac, not Jew against Gentile, and it establishes that biological descent never by itself determined the promised line. The Malachi quotation carries an Edom-and-nations background that only intertextual work makes visible. Exodus 33 turns out to be a golden-calf text in which Israel itself survives by mercy. And the chapter ends with Hosea applied to Gentiles and a remnant held out for Israel, with neither half swallowing the other.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** I expected Romans 9 to settle this and it did not; it sharpened the question instead. Which means the next chapter cannot be avoided any longer. Romans 10 is the strongest text against the position I brought into this investigation, and I am going to run straight at it.

Chapter 21: Romans 10 — the strongest text against where I started

I said at the beginning of this investigation that I would run at the texts most likely to destroy my position rather than around them. This is where that promise gets tested, and I want the framing on the record before the evidence, so nobody has to take my word afterward that I went in unprotected.

Here is my original position, stated as I actually held it, because a careless summary of it is easy to produce and I have produced one.

When my relative pressed me with Mark 16 and Matthew 28 and James 4:17 and Acts 8:4, I answered that preaching was not my calling — that gifts are distributed unevenly, that Ephesians 4:11 names evangelist as a specific function rather than a universal one, and that 1 Peter 3:15 asks readiness to answer rather than initiative to proclaim.

What I was **not** saying, and want on the record before the chapter goes any further: I was not defending silence. I had been speaking about Yah and about Messiah in the ordinary course of my life for years, and I held then, as I hold now, that anyone who genuinely believes should have something

to say about it and be ready to give an answer for it. I had also learned early in my walk not to force it on people, which is a different lesson and one I still think was right.

What I rejected was narrower: that Scripture makes every believer an evangelist, that every believer is therefore obliged to proclaim outwardly in that same proactive manner — and above all that failing to do so is sin. That last clause is where the argument actually lived.

And Romans 10 contains this:

> How then will they call on him in whom they have not believed? And how are they to believe in him of whom they have never heard? And how are they to hear without someone preaching? (Romans 10:14)

That is the passage a person quotes to someone like me. I knew it was coming. This chapter is where I stopped walking around it.

THE SUBJECT HAS NOT CHANGED

The first thing that matters is structural, and it is easy to lose because chapter divisions are later conveniences.

Romans 10 opens with Paul saying his heart's desire and prayer to God for **them** is that they may be saved. Them is Israel. The subject has not changed from chapter 9, and it does not change before chapter 11 picks it up again.

So Romans 10 is not a disconnected missionary handbook that happens to sit between two chapters about Israel. Its immediate subject is Israel's response to Messiah, and that governs how the preaching chain in verses 14 and 15 may be read.

That observation does not settle anything by itself. It sets the frame, and the frame is Paul's, not mine.

THEIR PROBLEM IS NOT A LACK OF ZEAL

Paul says they have a zeal for God, but not according to knowledge. Whatever is wrong is not indifference. That matters because it removes the easiest caricature available in this argument, and I had used that caricature.

DEUTERONOMY 30 IS DOING THE WORK, AGAIN

Then Paul's argument about the righteousness of faith turns out to be built out of Torah rather than against it. He reaches for Deuteronomy 30 — the word is very near you, in your mouth and in your heart — and uses it to describe the nearness of the message of faith.

This is the third or fourth time in this book that Paul's critique of the misuse of Torah has turned out to be made from **inside** Torah. I am noting the pattern because it is consistent enough to be a feature of how Paul argues, and because it cuts against a reading of Paul I brought with me.

ROMANS 10:4, WHICH CANNOT BE SETTLED IN ENGLISH

> For Christ is the **end** of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes (Romans 10:4, ESV)

> ***TELOS* AT ROMANS 10:4**
>
> τέλος (*telos*) — and the English word chosen to render it carries the argument.
>
> *Telos* can mean **termination**, the point at which something stops. It can also mean **goal**, **completion**, the end *toward which* something was aimed — the sense in which a road has an end, or a purpose is achieved.
>
> The ESV's *end* preserves the ambiguity of the Greek only by accident, because the English word has both senses too. But readers do not hear both. They hear the first.
>
> **Romans 10:4 cannot be settled from the English word "end."** Anyone quoting *end of the law* as though the verse said *Torah is abolished* has substituted one sense of an ambiguous noun for the verse itself. That is not an argument about Paul. It is an argument about a translator's word.

I am not resolving *telos* here. Chapter 15's definition of fulfilment — a pattern reaching its reality — is obviously relevant, and I am deliberately not using it, because using my own earlier conclusion to disambiguate a contested word would be circular.

THEN ACCESS UNIVERSALIZES

Paul goes on to say there is no distinction between Jew and Greek, that the same Lord is Lord of all and bestows riches on all who call on Him.

Expansion without erasure — the same pattern Part III kept producing. Israel remains the immediate problem of the chapter; salvation in Messiah is not ethnically restricted. Both at once, again, with neither half permitted to consume the other.

THE CHAIN, WHICH I AM NOT GOING TO SOFTEN

> How then will they call on him in whom they have not believed? And how are they to believe in him of whom they have never heard? And how are they to hear without someone preaching? And how are they to preach unless they are sent? (Romans 10:14-15)

Formally: **call ← believe ← hear ← proclaimer ← sending.**

This is a genuine and strong establishment of the necessity of proclamation. I am not going to soften it, qualify it into uselessness, or discover that it means something other than what it says. Faith ordinarily comes through someone announcing something. That is Paul's claim and it is plain.

If the chapter ended at *someone preaching*, my original position would be in serious trouble.

BUT PAUL ADDS ONE MORE LINK, AND IT IS THE PIVOT

It does not end there. Paul adds a fourth link that I had never once heard quoted in any of these conversations, including by me: **and how are they to preach unless they are sent?**

ROMANS 10:14–15 — WHAT THE CHAIN ESTABLISHES

PROPOSITION	STATUS
Faith ordinarily requires proclamation	**ESTABLISHED**
Proclaimers are **SENT**	**ESTABLISHED** — Paul himself adds it as the final link
Every believer personally occupies the sent-herald role	**NOT ESTABLISHED BY THIS TEXT**
Every believer is commanded here to proclaim to every region	**NOT ESTABLISHED BY THIS TEXT**

> The final link **cuts against** the universal-obligation reading rather than for it. Paul does not stop at *someone must preach*. He adds *unless they are sent*, which introduces **sending as a necessary link in the chain**.
>
> And I have to be careful about exactly how much that buys, because I overreached here on a first pass. The clause establishes that legitimate proclamation presupposes sending. It does **not**, by itself, tell me how narrowly or broadly Yahweh sends people. So it does not establish that every believer occupies the heralding role — and it equally does not establish that the sent are few.

That is the pivot of this whole chapter, and I want to be honest about how it felt. The text most likely to overturn my position contains, in its own last clause, the distinction my

position was trying to draw. I did not put it there and I had not known it was there.

> ***KĒRYSSŌ* AND *APOSTELLŌ***
>
> κηρύσσω (*kēryssō*) — to herald, to proclaim publicly. It carries public-announcement force. It is not "mention in conversation."
>
> ἀποστέλλω (*apostellō*) — to send. The root of ἀπόστολος (*apostolos*), "sent one."
>
> **And the brake, because the word-family link is real and does not prove what I would like it to.** *Apostellō* here does **not** restrict the sending to the Twelve. The vocabulary establishes that commission is in view; it does not establish a closed office.
>
> Both overreadings fail: *the logic involves commission* may not be collapsed into *only apostles may proclaim*, any more than *someone must preach* may be collapsed into *therefore everyone must*.

And Isaiah 52:7, which Paul quotes next about the feet of those who bring good news, is not a generic image either. In Isaiah it is a **covenantal herald** announcing to Zion that her God reigns — a specific figure with a specific message to a specific city.

AND NOW THE PART THAT COSTS ME

Here is where the chapter takes back something larger than what it gave.

Romans 10:18 says: *Their voice has gone out to all the earth, and their words to the ends of the world.* And that verse has been doing quiet work in my position for a long time, because

the second phrase is οἰκουμένη (*oikoumenē*) — the same word as Matthew 24:14.

The bridge writes itself. Paul says the message reached the *oikoumenē*; Matthew 24:14 says the end comes after the good news is proclaimed in the *oikoumenē*; therefore the condition was met in the first century.

I wanted that bridge. So I checked whether Paul chose the word.

He did not. Romans 10:18 is a quotation of Psalm 19:4, and the Septuagint of that Psalm reads:

> εἰς πᾶσαν τὴν **γῆν** ἐξῆλθεν ὁ φθόγγος αὐτῶν καὶ εἰς τὰ πέρατα τῆς **οἰκουμένης** τὰ ῥήματα αὐτῶν

Both γῆν (*gēn*) and οἰκουμένης (*oikoumenēs*) are inherited from the Psalm, verbatim. Paul is quoting, not describing.

> **FINDING — AGAINST MY OWN HYPOTHESIS, AND IT IS THE REASON THIS CHAPTER IS IN THE BOOK**
>
> An argument of the form *"Paul says the good news reached the* oikoumenē*, the same word as Matthew 24:14, therefore Matthew 24:14's condition was met"* rests on **a word Paul borrowed from a Psalm about the heavens declaring the glory of God.**
>
> The lexical overlap is real. It is **not independent attestation** of Paul's own geographic assessment, because Paul did not select the term.
>
> This is the never-collapse-evidence-types rule operating on a case where I would have strongly preferred the other outcome. The overlap is **intertextual**, not independent-lexical, and it may not be reported as the latter.

I have spent chapters warning about arguments that borrow strength from a shared word. This was mine, and it does not survive its own test.

AND A TRANSLATION PROBLEM THAT INVERTS THE WHOLE THING

One more finding, which is the strongest practical argument I have found for working in the source languages.

TEXTUAL NOTE — ROMANS 10:18, WHERE TWO GOOD TRANSLATIONS MAP THE SAME WORDS OPPOSITELY

GREEK POSITION	GREEK WORD	ESV RENDERS	CJB RENDERS
first	γῆν (*gē*)	"earth"	"**WORLD**"
second	οἰκουμένης (*oikoumenē*)	"world"	"**EARTH**"

The CJB reverses the two English terms relative to the Greek word order. Neither translation is *wrong as English*.

But the practical consequence is severe. Anyone building the Matthew 24:14 bridge while reading the CJB in English will attach *oikoumenē* to the **wrong half of the verse** — matching Matthew's term to the clause that is actually rendering *gē*.

No amount of care at the English level detects this. Only the Greek does. I had been reading these verses in English for years and would never have found it.

ROLE AND ACT, WHICH IS WHERE THE CHAPTER LEAVES ME

So what do I actually have, after running at the text I was most afraid of?

The chain stands, unsoftened: faith ordinarily comes through proclamation, and proclaimers are sent. The differentiated-calling reading survives — it survives on Paul's own final clause, not on my preference. And the *oikoumenē* bridge that I had been leaning on is gone, killed by the same discipline that saved the other half.

> **FINDING — THE FORMULATION THAT HOLDS BOTH HALVES**
>
> **Not everyone is an evangelist — and that does not relieve believers of responsibility to speak truthfully about Messiah when faithfulness, opportunity, or direct questioning calls for it.**
>
> The body of Messiah contains differentiated callings, and Scripture does not portray every member as occupying every office. That is real.
>
> And the second half of that formulation is not a correction to me, because it was never in dispute on my side. What Romans 10 corrected was not a commitment to silence. It made me take the indispensable place of proclamation **in the body as a whole** far more seriously than I had — and it left standing the question the argument started over, which is not whether anyone speaks but **who is sent to do what**.

That formulation is not a compromise between the two sides of the original argument. It is what is left when both sides are made to say only what their texts support — and it concedes more to my relative's concern than my opening answer did.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Romans 10's subject is still Israel, and its argument about faith-righteousness is built from Deuteronomy rather than against it. *Telos* at 10:4 cannot be settled in English. The preaching chain is genuine and is not softened here — and its final link, *unless they are sent*, makes sending a necessary part of the chain, without establishing by itself that every believer occupies the heralding role and without telling me how broadly the sending extends. Against that, 10:18's *oikoumenē* is quoted verbatim from the Septuagint Psalm and is therefore not independent attestation of anything, which removes a bridge I had been using. And the CJB inverts *gē* and *oikoumenē* relative to the Greek, so the bridge cannot even be checked reliably in English.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. The text I expected to lose on gave me the distinction I needed and took away an argument I had been relying on. That is what running at something rather than around it actually looks like. Romans 11 is next, and it is where Paul says what he thinks happens to Israel.

Chapter 22: Romans 11 — remnant, grafting, and “all Israel”

Paul asks my question for me, in the first verse, and answers it before I can get comfortable.

> I ask, then, has God rejected his people? **By no means!** (Romans 11:1)

The Greek is μὴ γένοιτο (*mē genoito*), Paul’s strongest available idiom of rejection. And his first piece of evidence is himself: *for I too am an Israelite, a descendant of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin*.

Present tense, again, exactly as in chapter 9. Paul the apostle to the Gentiles, writing about the inclusion of Gentiles, describes himself in the present as an Israelite of a named tribe.

ELIJAH, AND WHAT A REMNANT IS FOR

Paul’s second piece of evidence is Elijah, who thought he was the only one left and was told that seven thousand remained.

That is a specific kind of argument. A remnant is not a replacement of the people; it is a portion **of** the people, preserved within it. Paul says that at the present time there is a remnant chosen by grace — which means the present situ-

ation is not unprecedented in Israel's own history, and Israel's own history is where Paul goes to explain it.

HARDENING, WITH ITS LIMITS STATED IMMEDIATELY

Paul does say a hardening has occurred. He does not leave it unqualified, and the qualifications arrive fast enough that removing them requires effort.

> Did they stumble in order that they might fall? **By no means!** (Romans 11:11)

Same idiom, second time. And then the purpose clause: through their trespass salvation has come to the Gentiles, *so as to make Israel jealous* — which presupposes that Israel is still in view, still the subject of a plan, not a closed file.

> **TWO *MĒ GENOITO* DENIALS**
>
> Paul's two μὴ γένοιτο denials — *has God rejected his people?* and *did they stumble so as to fall?* — are explicit text, and together their evidence CONTRADICTS a reading in which Israel has been set aside permanently.
>
> They do **not** establish what positive outcome Paul expects, how it comes about, or when. Refuting one reading does not install its opposite, and Paul spends the rest of the chapter on a question he has not yet answered.

THE OLIVE TREE, AND THE ABSENCES THAT CARRY THE WEIGHT

> if the root is holy, so are the branches. But if some of the branches were broken off, and you, although a wild olive shoot, were grafted in among the others and now share in the nourishing root of the olive tree (Romans 11:16-17)

> ***ENKENTRIZŌ* — TO GRAFT IN**
>
> ἐγκεντρίζω (*enkentrizō*) — to graft in. Used six times in this passage and nowhere else in the New Testament.
>
> Grafting is a horticultural operation in which a shoot is inserted **into an existing rooted tree** and draws its life from that root. The tree is not replaced. The root is not replaced. The graft is what changes.

And what Paul does **not** say is load-bearing. He does not say the Gentile believer becomes a second tree. He does not say the old tree is destroyed and a new one planted. He does not say the broken branches are replaced in kind.

Wild branches are grafted into an existing cultivated tree. That is incorporation, and it is the same structure Chapter 19 arrived at from the other direction.

OPEN QUESTION — WHAT THE ROOT IS, AND WHY I AM NOT SETTLING IT

Candidates: Abraham and the patriarchal promises; the covenant promises generally; Israel's covenantal root; Messiah; some combination.

Romans 11 never says *the root is Christ*. It says Gentiles share in the nourishing root, and that the root supports **you**.

There is a contextual lean, and I record it as contextual rather than lexical: the patriarchal framing of Romans 9 through 11, and especially 11:28's *beloved for the sake of their forefathers*, weighs toward the patriarchal-promise reading.

That is a lean, not a finding. I am holding the referent open **because this book's own identity language depends on it**, and a question whose answer would conveniently shore up my vocabulary is exactly the question to be most careful with.

THE WARNING, WHICH IS LONGER THAN THE PROMISE

Then Paul turns and addresses Gentile readers directly, and the tone changes.

Do not be arrogant toward the branches. If you are, remember that you do not support the root; the root supports you. And if God did not spare the natural branches, neither will He spare you.

That is severe and it is symmetrical. The same principle that removed branches can remove these. Faith is the dividing

issue in both directions, and standing is by faith rather than by category.

And then the detail that is easy to read past: natural branches can be grafted back — *into their own olive tree*. Their own. Paul's possessive, not mine.

ROMANS 11:25, AND A WORD I CANNOT SETTLE

> a partial hardening has come upon Israel, until **the fullness of the Gentiles** has come in (Romans 11:25)

"THE FULLNESS OF THE NATIONS"

τὸ πλήρωμα τῶν ἐθνῶν (*to plērōma tōn ethnōn*) — "the fullness of the nations."

Not established: whether *plērōma* here denotes a number, a covenantal fullness, the completion of a mission to the nations, a representative inclusion, or something else.

This touches the original proclamation question directly, because *the fullness of the nations coming in* is scope language of exactly the kind this book has spent three Parts learning not to read confidently. I am leaving it open rather than making it mean what would be useful.

AND THEN A FINDING I DID NOT EXPECT AT ALL

Paul continues: *and in this way all Israel will be saved*, and supports it with a quotation about the Deliverer and Zion.

Two things happen in that sentence, and both constrain what anyone may build on it.

The first is small and clarifying. οὕτως (*houtōs*) is an **adverb** — *thus, in this manner*. Chronology cannot be imported from the English word *so*. Paul may be saying *in this manner all Israel will be saved* rather than *after the Gentile fullness, then Israel*. The adverb does not settle the verse. It removes the sequential reading's claim to be the obvious one.

The second is larger, and it is the strongest thing in this chapter.

TEXTUAL NOTE — THREE WITNESSES, THREE PREPOSITIONS, AND PAUL MATCHES NEITHER SOURCE

WITNESS	TEXT	PREPOSITION	DIRECTION
MT HEBREW	וּבָא לְצִיּוֹן גּוֹאֵל	לְ *(l')*	**TO** Zion
LXX	καὶ ἥξει ἕνεκεν Σιὼν ὁ ῥυόμενος	ἕνεκεν *(heneken)*	**FOR THE SAKE OF** Zion
PAUL, ROMANS 11:26	Ἥξει ἐκ Σιὼν ὁ Ῥυόμενος	ἐκ *(ek)*	**OUT OF / FROM** Zion

Three witnesses. Three prepositions. Three different directions of travel. **Paul matches neither the Hebrew nor the Septuagint.**

This is a different and stronger phenomenon than the one in the last chapter. At Romans 10:18 Paul quoted the Septuagint *verbatim*. Here he matches no extant witness I examined.

The constraint that follows: any argument resting on the **direction** of the Deliverer's coming — to Zion, from Zion, for the sake of Zion — is resting on a word that differs across every witness. I may not build on it, and neither may a reading that opposes mine.

Not established: whether Paul used a Greek text now lost, quoted from memory, deliberately reshaped the wording, or conflated Isaiah 59:20 with another passage.

And a distinction that matters more than it sounds. This is a **source-text** divergence — Hebrew against Greek against Paul. It is not a **translation** divergence — ESV against CJB against RVR1960. Different category, different count, and the two tallies may not be merged. Collapsing them would inflate both and misdescribe what kind of uncertainty this book is carrying.

OPEN QUESTION — WHAT THE APOSTLES' USE OF THE SEPTUAGINT COSTS A SOURCE-LANGUAGE-FIRST METHOD

This is the second chapter running in which the text behind an apostolic quotation is not the Hebrew. At Romans 10:18 Paul quoted the Septuagint verbatim. Here he matches neither the Hebrew nor the Septuagint.

And it is not confined to Paul. At the Jerusalem Council, James settles the question of Gentile inclusion by quoting **Amos 9:11-12** — in a form that follows the **Septuagint**, where the Hebrew text reads differently at the decisive phrase. The argument that admits Gentiles without circumcision is made from a Greek translation.

This is a real cost to a method that says *go to the source languages*, and I am not going to pretend otherwise. If the Hebrew is the source and the Greek is a translation, then apostolic arguments are sometimes built on the translation — and the conclusions drawn from them are in the canon.

Options, none adopted: that the Septuagint preserves a Hebrew reading now lost; that apostolic authority extends to the use made of a text; that the argument does not in fact depend on the divergent phrase; that "source language" is the wrong frame for a first-century Jewish writer whose Scriptures circulated in Greek.

Not resolved. It stands as a question against this investigation's own method rather than against anyone else's, which is where it belongs.

And the third element: Paul immediately glosses *all Israel* with a prophecy about banishing ungodliness **from Jacob**.

If *all Israel* meant exclusively the combined Jew-and-Gentile assembly, it is difficult to explain why Paul reaches for a prophecy about Jacob to explain it. That does not eliminate broader covenant-people readings. It places substantial weight on Israel remaining central — and I record it as **intertextual** evidence, not lexical.

OPEN QUESTION — "ALL ISRAEL," FOUR READINGS, NONE SELECTED

πᾶς Ἰσραήλ (*pas Israēl*): ethnic or national Israel; the elect within Israel; the total covenant people including Gentiles; a future restoration of Jewish Israel.

Not settled by theological instinct, including mine. It stays open, as it did when Chapter 19 reached it from the other side.

THE STATEMENT ANY REPLACEMENT MODEL HAS TO RECKON WITH

> For the gifts and the calling of God are **irrevocable** (Romans 11:29)

***AMETAMELĒTA* — IRREVOCABLE, AND PLACED FIRST**

ἀμεταμέλητα (*ametamelēta*) — "not to be repented of, not regretted, irrevocable."

Paul places it **first in the clause**: ἀμεταμέλητα γὰρ τὰ χαρίσματα καὶ ἡ κλῆσις τοῦ Θεοῦ, giving the word marked prominence. Its position reinforces the force of "irrevocable," though word order alone should not bear the argument.

And the verse before it: *as regards election, they are beloved for the sake of their forefathers.*

So: has Yahweh replaced Israel? Paul's answer is available in his own vocabulary and I do not need to supply one. *Mē genoito*, twice. Grafted **in**, not planted beside. Their **own** olive tree. Beloved for the sake of the fathers. Irrevocable, and placed first.

Does the assembly therefore *become* Israel? Paul does not say that either, and the olive tree is precisely the image that would let him if he wanted to. Branches grafted into a tree are not the tree, and they are not a second tree. They share a root.

WHAT THIS DOES TO MY OWN VOCABULARY

Which brings the discipline back onto me. *Messianic Israelite* is the term I find useful, and Romans 11 is exactly where I could make it do more work than it has earned.

Paul's language outranks my label: grafted in, brought near, sharing the root, beloved for the sake of the fathers. **Text, then synthesis, then label** — and the label goes last precisely because it is mine.

MERCY IS WHERE PAUL ENDS

Paul does not close this argument with a system. He closes it with mercy — *that He may have mercy on all* — and then

with doxology, and the doxology contains a line that reads like a rebuke of the entire enterprise of settling this:

How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways.

I am not going to pretend that resolves anything. But a chapter that ends in stated incomprehension is a strange place to build a confident system, and I have watched confident systems built here, including one of mine.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Paul denies twice, in his strongest idiom, that God has rejected His people or that Israel stumbled so as to fall. The olive tree is incorporation into an existing rooted tree, with the Gentile warning longer than the promise and natural branches able to be grafted back into *their own* tree. The root's referent stays open because this book's identity language depends on it. *Houtōs* is an adverb, so chronology cannot be read out of the English *so*. And at 11:26 three witnesses give three prepositions with Paul matching neither source — a source-text divergence that may not be merged with the translation tally, and that forbids any argument resting on the Deliverer's direction of travel. *All Israel* remains open; *irrevocable* does not.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** Romans 9 through 11 is finished, and Israel has not been written out of it. Which leaves the historical question the original argument actually turned on, and which no amount of Romans can settle: had the good news already gone out before the year 70?

Chapter 23: had the good news already gone out before AD 70?

This is the historical question the original argument actually turned on, and no amount of Romans settles it.

My position had a load-bearing beam in it: that Matthew 24:14's condition — this good news proclaimed in the *oikoumenē*, and then the end — had already been met in the first century. If that is true, a great deal follows. If it is not, a great deal of what I had been saying does not stand.

So I went to find out, and I want to report the result in the order I got it, because the order is the point.

FIRST, THE WORD

Matthew 24:14's scope term is ἐν ὅλῃ τῇ οἰκουμένῃ — *in the whole oikoumenē*. That is Matthew's word, and Chapter 7 already established that Luke uses the same word of Caesar's empire and of a first-century famine.

So the natural next move is to ask whether the apostolic writers say the *oikoumenē* was reached. And here is where I had been operating on an assumption I had never checked.

THE TABLE THAT CHANGED THE CHAPTER

I set every scope term in every proclamation text I had been leaning on side by side, in the Greek.

THE SCOPE TERMS, CHECKED IN THE GREEK

TEXT	GREEK SCOPE TERM	WHOSE WORD?
MATTHEW 24:14	ἐν ὅλῃ τῇ οἰκουμένῃ	**MATTHEW'S**
LUKE 2:1	πᾶσαν τὴν οἰκουμένην	**LUKE'S**
ACTS 11:28	ἐφ' ὅλην τὴν οἰκουμένην	**LUKE'S**
ROMANS 10:18	πᾶσαν τὴν γῆν … τὰ πέρατα τῆς οἰκουμένης	**QUOTED VERBATIM FROM LXX PSALM 18:5 — NOT PAUL'S OWN**
COLOSSIANS 1:6	ἐν παντὶ τῷ κόσμῳ	**PAUL'S — BUT A DIFFERENT WORD**
COLOSSIANS 1:23	ἐν πάσῃ κτίσει τῇ ὑπὸ τὸν οὐρανόν	**PAUL'S — A THIRD DIFFERENT WORD**

FINDING — AGAINST MY OWN POSITION, AND IT IS THE RESULT I DID NOT EXPECT

Paul never chooses *oikoumenē* in any proclamation text.

The single occurrence in Paul is Romans 10:18, where the last chapter verified he is quoting the Septuagint word for word. Where Paul writes in his own words, he uses κόσμος (*kosmos*) at Colossians 1:6 and κτίσις (*ktisis*) at Colossians 1:23. Two different words, neither of them Matthew's.

So the move I had been making — *Paul says the good news reached the whole world, which is Matthew's* oikoumenē*, therefore Matthew 24:14 was fulfilled* — **does not survive a check of the Greek.** It relied on **English** supplying a single word, *world*, for three distinct Greek terms, only one of which Matthew used, and that one Paul did not choose.

The bridge is not where I thought it was. Luke, not Paul, is the real lexical control on Matthew's word.

That is the second time in two chapters that a bridge I was relying on has failed for the same reason: I had been reading an English word and thinking I was reading a Greek one.

WHAT LUKE ACTUALLY GIVES, WHICH IS NOT NOTHING

Losing Paul as the control does not leave the question empty. It relocates it.

Luke uses *oikoumenē* twice, and both are bounded. Caesar's census covers the *oikoumenē* and Caesar did not tax the Americas. The famine comes over the *oikoumenē* and Luke reports it happening under Claudius. Those are strong controls on the word's range, and they are from the same author writing in the same period.

Luke also gives the programme: witnesses in Jerusalem, in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth. Acts is structured as the working-out of that sentence, and by its close the message has reached Rome.

PAUL'S OWN LANGUAGE, WHICH IS GENUINELY STRIKING

And Paul's words, on their own terms rather than borrowed for a bridge, are still remarkable. Colossians 1:6 says the message is bearing fruit *in the whole kosmos*. Colossians 1:23 says it was proclaimed *in all creation under heaven*. Romans 15:19 and 23 say his assignment from Jerusalem around to Illyricum is brought to completion and that he has no room left to work there.

A first-century writer describing his own moment used language that sounds, to me, like the job was substantially done.

THE CONSISTENCY POINT, AND IT CUTS BOTH WAYS

Here is the argument I find genuinely strong, and I want to state it as what it is rather than more.

If someone insists Matthew 24:14 cannot have been fulfilled because the message had not reached every location and every individual, then Paul's statements create a problem for them: *the whole kosmos*, *all creation under heaven*.

One can answer that Paul is using rhetorical universal language. That is fair, and probably right.

> **FINDING — A CONSISTENCY REQUIREMENT, NOT AN ARGUMENT FOR MY POSITION**
>
> But then the same rhetorical possibility must at least be **considered** for Matthew's universal proclamation language. Demanding hyper-literal exhaustiveness from Matthew while allowing first-century rhetorical universality in Paul requires an explanation of the difference.
>
> That is a consistency requirement. It is not evidence that Matthew 24:14 was fulfilled, and I am not going to let it quietly become one.

THE BRAKE AGAINST MYSELF, AT EQUAL FORCE

Paul says whole world, therefore Matthew 24:14 was fulfilled is **not enough**. Different author, different vocabulary — now verified — different rhetorical setting, different proposition.

Paul never writes that Matthew 24:14 has been fulfilled. Nobody in the New Testament does.

	STATUS
Direct fulfilment claim	**NOT PRESENT**
Strong comparative evidence	**PRESENT**
Historical plausibility support	**STRONG**
Final identification	Still requires Matthew's own chronology, and possibly first-century evidence outside Scripture

A CORRECTION I HAD TO MAKE AGAINST MY OWN FORMULATION

While working the adjacent question — whether the mission reached the people it needed to reach — I produced a formulation that went beyond the evidence, and I am keeping it visible rather than replacing it silently.

The formulation that overreached, and the narrower one that survived

Acts contains a striking pattern. Paul is told in Corinth that Yahweh has many people in this city, before they have believed. He is forbidden to speak the word in Asia and redirected to Macedonia. Lydia's heart is opened. Philip is sent to one man on one road.

From that I drew a conclusion about divine foreknowledge governing the mission's reach, and I stated it in a way that made the mission's

> completeness a function of God knowing in advance exactly who needed to hear.
>
> That went further than the texts support. What Acts shows is that **Paul's movements were directed** — sometimes toward, sometimes explicitly away. It does not tell me the mechanism, and it does not license a general theory about who the mission was ultimately for.
>
> The narrower version survives and is actually more useful: Paul did not need to know whether anyone remained to be reached **through him**, because the direction was not his to determine. That bears on Romans 15's *no room left to work here* — it makes the statement intelligible as a report about an assignment rather than a census of a region.
>
> Recorded as an interpretation drawn from narrative pattern, not as a doctrine of foreknowledge. The overreaching version is left in view because catching it is the part worth keeping.

THE QUESTION, RESTATED AS FOUR PROPOSITIONS

Stating it this way is what finally made the argument tractable, and it is where this chapter lands.

FINDING — FOUR PROPOSITIONS, AND ONLY ONE OF THEM IS IN DISPUTE

	PROPOSITION	STATUS
A	Yeshua commissioned specific apostles and disciples	**CLEARLY YES**
B	The first-century apostolic mission expanded to the nations	**CLEARLY YES**
C	Proclamation was necessary for faith and hearing	**CLEARLY YES** (Chapter 21)
D	**EVERY BELIEVER IN EVERY LATER ERA IS INDIVIDUALLY UNDER THE SAME GEOGRAPHICALLY UNIVERSAL APOSTOLIC COMMISSION**	**STILL REQUIRES PROOF — IT CANNOT BE ASSUMED FROM A, B AND C**

A, B and C are not controversial and I grant them without reservation. My relative was right about all three, and my original answer was weakest precisely where it seemed to be brushing past them.

D is the whole dispute, and D does not follow from the others. That is not a preterist claim. It is a claim about what an argument establishes.

And if Matthew 24:14's proclamation was fulfilled within a first-century horizon, then using *that verse* to establish D becomes harder still — which is exactly where the original objection has been heading since the first page of this book.

WHAT I HAVE, AND WHAT I DO NOT

I do not have a verse saying Matthew 24:14 was fulfilled. I have looked, and it is not there.

I have Luke's bounded use of Matthew's word, Paul's striking completion language in different vocabulary, an apostolic generation that wrote as though the assignment had been substantially discharged, and a consistency requirement that anyone reading Matthew hyper-literally has to answer.

And I have one bridge fewer than I started the chapter with, removed by my own checking.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Paul never chooses *oikoumenē* in a proclamation text; the one instance is a Septuagint quotation, and in his own words he writes *kosmos* and *ktisis*. So the popular bridge from Paul to Matthew 24:14 rests on an English word doing the work of three Greek ones, and it does not survive. Luke, not Paul, is the real control on Matthew's term, and Luke's two uses are bounded. No New Testament writer states that Matthew 24:14 has been fulfilled. What remains is strong comparative evidence, strong historical plausibility, and a consistency requirement that cuts both ways. Propositions A, B and C are granted; D — that every believer in every era carries the same geographically universal commission — still requires proof and does not follow from them.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. The question is now stated precisely enough to be answered, and one text has been standing behind the whole argument since my relative first raised it. Matthew 28, read in its own context, with attention to who was in the room.

Chapter 24: Matthew 28 — the Great Commission in context

This is the verse my relative put in front of me, and it is the strongest remaining text against where I started. I am approaching it the way I approached Romans 10: directly, with the outcome unprotected, and with the framing stated before the evidence.

If Matthew 28 says what he took it to say, my original answer does not survive.

WHO IS ACTUALLY IN THE ROOM

> Now the eleven disciples went to Galilee, to the mountain to which Jesus had directed them (Matthew 28:16)

The eleven. Matthew tells us who receives this, and the first interpretive step is to notice that he bothered to.

That does **not** mean the command has no continuing implications, and I want to block that inference immediately because it is the cheap version of my own position. It means the first thing established is that Yeshua is commissioning a specific apostolic group, and anything beyond that has to be argued rather than assumed.

IT FLOWS FROM ENTHRONEMENT

> All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me (Matthew 28:18)

The commission does not begin with a task. It begins with a claim to authority, and the language is Daniel 7's — authority given to one like a son of man.

This is a **royal** commission, issued on the basis of an enthronement. It is not general encouragement that evangelism is a worthwhile activity. Whatever else follows, it follows from a throne.

THE FINITE VERB IS "MAKE DISCIPLES"

Here is the first thing that surprised me, and it is verifiable in any interlinear.

MATTHEW 28:19 — THE FINITE VERB

πορευθέντες οὖν μαθητεύσατε πάντα τὰ ἔθνη, βαπτίζοντες … διδάσκοντες

πορευθέντες (*poreuthentes*) — **aorist participle**, literally "having gone." Morphologically it is not the finite imperative. But in this construction it can function as an **attendant-circumstance** participle, taking imperatival force from the verb it depends on — so the grammar must not be used to make the going optional or incidental, and I am not going to gloss it as a casual "as you go."

μαθητεύσατε (*mathēteusate*) — **the finite imperative**, and the syntactic centre of the sentence. *Make disciples.*

βαπτίζοντες (*baptizontes*), διδάσκοντες (*didaskontes*) — present participles: baptizing, teaching. These explain **how**.

The syntactic centre of the commission is *make disciples*. Going is attendant circumstance and carries the force of the imperative with it; baptizing and teaching describe how the disciple-making is done.

I want to be careful not to make too much of that, because this is a place where a grammatical observation can be turned into a theological argument it cannot carry. The morphology does not make the going incidental, and it certainly does not mean *nobody goes anywhere* — Acts is the counter-evidence, and an attendant-circumstance participle shares the imperative's force rather than demoting it. What the syntax does establish is that the command's **content** is discipleship, which is a longer and different thing than announcing a message once.

And that distinction matters for the original argument, because **evangelism and discipleship are not the same**

activity, and my relative and I had been using them interchangeably. So had I, when it suited me.

"ALL NATIONS," AND MATTHEW'S OWN DEVELOPMENT

> make disciples of **all nations** (Matthew 28:19)

That phrase has to be read against Matthew's own earlier material, and the contrast is stark.

In Matthew 10, Yeshua sends the twelve and tells them to go nowhere among the Gentiles and enter no town of the Samaritans, but rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. In Matthew 15 He says He was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.

Then Matthew 28 says all nations.

THE JERUSALEM COUNCIL, AND THE CATEGORY THAT ALREADY EXISTED

Within roughly two decades, the question Matthew 28 opens had to be settled in practice: on what terms do the nations come in?

Israel already had a category for the outsider who attached himself to the covenant community — the גֵּר (*ger*), the sojourner or resident alien. Torah legislates for him repeatedly: he keeps the Sabbath, he may eat the Passover if circumcised, he is to be loved as oneself, and one law is to apply to the native-born and to the *ger* alike. The category is not an afterthought; it is built in.

What the Jerusalem Council of Acts 15 decided was **not** that the nations could come in — Torah already knew that. The immediate dispute was whether Gentile believers had to be circumcised and required to keep the law of Moses as a condition of belonging. The Council refused to impose that entry requirement, and issued four requirements in its letter instead.

What Acts 15 implies about the Gentiles' **subsequent** relationship to the rest of Torah is a further question, and verse 21 — *Moses has been read every Sabbath in the synagogues* — is one reason not to pretend the Council answered more than it did.

So the council is doing something narrower and more interesting than inventing Gentile inclusion. It is deciding which of the existing categories the incoming nations occupy, in a situation the earlier categories had not been written for.

> **FINDING — A GENUINE DEVELOPMENT, WITH THE RESURRECTION STANDING BETWEEN THE TWO**
>
> Matthew contains a real development, and Messiah's death and resurrection stand between the two commissions.
>
> The mission **begins Israel-centred** and **later expands to the nations**. Matthew 10 does not need to be distorted to defend Matthew 28, and Matthew 28 does not need to be suppressed to preserve Israel's priority. Both belong to the story, in that order, and the order is the point.
>
> Flattening the earthly Israel-centred mission, the initial commission to the Twelve, the later Gentile mission, Paul's particular apostleship and the incorporation language of Part III into one undifferentiated "Great Commission" is how this argument goes wrong on both sides. It went wrong that way for me.

AND THE COMMISSION GENUINELY ESTABLISHES A NATIONS MISSION

Now the part that costs me, and I am stating it as plainly as I can.

> **MATTHEW 28 AND THE MISSION TO THE NATIONS**
>
> Matthew 28 **establishes** that Yeshua commanded the eleven to disciple all nations.
>
> If someone claims the apostles were never commissioned beyond Israel, **Matthew 28 does not allow it.** The mission genuinely expands, by explicit command, from a risen Messiah claiming all authority.
>
> Any reading — including any version of mine — that needs this text to be smaller than it is has a problem with the text and not with its opponents.

My relative was right that Matthew 28 commands a mission to the nations. He was right that it is not a suggestion. Nothing in this chapter takes that back.

THE STRONGEST FORM OF THE ARGUMENT AGAINST ME

The serious question is not whether the eleven were commissioned. It is whether the commission is **structurally ongoing**, and there is a real argument that it is. I am going to give it its strongest form rather than the version that is easy to answer.

The argument runs: the eleven are told to teach the nations *to observe all that I have commanded you*. But *make disciples* is among the things He commanded them. So the disciples they make are themselves taught to make disciples, and the commission reproduces itself down the generations by its own internal logic. The closing promise — *I am with*

you always, to the end of the age — extends past the lifetime of anyone standing on that mountain, which suggests the command extends with it.

> **FINDING — THIS ARGUMENT IS NOT DISMISSED**
>
> That is a real argument, and it is probably the strongest textual case for the Great Commission being structurally ongoing rather than discharged by the apostolic generation.
>
> I do not have a refutation of it and I am not going to manufacture one. My original position treated the commission as simply completed, and this argument is the reason that position was too flat.

BUT "EVERYTHING I COMMANDED" DOES NOT DISTRIBUTE EVERY ROLE

Here is the distinction that does survive, and it is not a dodge — it is a reductio that Paul supplies.

If *teach them to observe everything I commanded you* distributed every command identically to every disciple, then every believer would have to be an apostle, a prophet, a teacher and an evangelist.

Paul explicitly denies that. *Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all teachers?* The expected answer to each is no. Ephesians 4:11 lists evangelist as one function among several given to some, for the equipping of all.

So a reading in which Matthew 28 distributes every apostolic role to every believer collides with Paul. And it collides with itself, since nobody actually holds it consistently: the same reader who says every believer must evangelize does not say every believer must be an apostle, though both are in *everything I commanded*.

CORPORATE MISSION, INDIVIDUAL VOCATION

Which produces the cleanest formulation I have reached, and it holds both halves without softening either.

FINDING — THE RESOLUTION, AND WHY IT IS NOT A COMPROMISE

Matthew 28 strongly supports: **Messiah's people possess an ongoing disciple-making mission.**

Paul's body theology supports: **members participate differently according to calling and gift.**

These do not contradict. A body can possess a mission collectively without every cell performing the same function — and the body metaphor is **Paul's own**, not an analogy imported to rescue a conclusion. That distinction matters to me, because rescuing conclusions with borrowed analogies is precisely what I have spent four Parts trying not to do.

This is more compatible with **both** Matthew 28 and Paul than *every believer must personally become a travelling evangelist* — and it is also what I was reaching for, imprecisely, when I said that preaching was not my calling and that I should not be held to the same outward proclaiming vocation as an evangelist.

WHAT THIS DOES TO THE ORIGINAL ARGUMENT

So let me put the two positions from that first conversation side by side, accurately.

My relative argued that believers are obligated to proclaim outwardly, from Mark 16, Matthew 28, James 4:17 and Acts 8:4. He did **not** argue that every believer holds an identical

evangelistic office; that is a strawman and I am not going to build it here in order to knock it down.

I argued that gifts are distributed unevenly, that evangelist is a named and specific function, and that 1 Peter 3:15 asks readiness to answer rather than initiative to proclaim. I was not arguing that believers may stay silent about Messiah, and I was not arguing that the question did not reach me. What I objected to was the claim that every believer must proclaim outwardly in that same proactive manner or else be in sin. Underneath that, unstated, I was also treating the commission as already discharged in the first century.

Four Parts later: his concern survives, and so does the central distinction I was drawing. What changed is not that I discovered believers should never be silent about Messiah — I had never held otherwise. What changed is that **I can no longer use a supposedly completed first-century proclamation as a cheap way of disposing of the continuing-mission question.** That was the load-bearing thing underneath my answer, and Chapter 23 took it apart.

So: the mission remains. The body participates in it. The question is how that participation differs according to calling, gift, circumstance and opportunity — which is closer to what I was trying to say at the time than to what either of us managed to say.

OPEN QUESTION — WHAT THE CORPORATE MISSION REQUIRES OF A MEMBER WHO IS NOT AN EVANGELIST

Saying the mission is corporate and participation differentiated does not tell anyone what to do on a Tuesday.

The formulation from Chapter 21 still stands as the closest I have: not everyone is an evangelist, and that does not relieve anyone of responsibility to speak truthfully about Messiah when faithfulness, opportunity or direct questioning calls for it.

That is a real answer and it is not a complete one. What a differentiated participation actually obliges remains underdetermined by everything I have assembled, and I would rather say so than issue a rule the texts have not given me.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Matthew 28 is a royal commission flowing from enthronement, given to the eleven, whose finite imperative is *make disciples* — with *go* an attendant participle that carries the imperative's force rather than being optional. Matthew's own development runs Israel-centred first and nations later, with the resurrection between, and neither commission needs to be suppressed to hold the other. The text genuinely establishes a mission to the nations, and no reading of mine is permitted to shrink it. The recursive argument for an ongoing commission is strong and is not refuted here. What does not follow is that every command distributes to every believer identically — Paul denies that outright. Corporate mission, individual vocation, on Paul's own metaphor.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. The question that started this investigation now has an answer I can defend, and it is not the answer I was defending when I was asked. Which clears the way for the thing I have been deferring since Part II: the ages, the resurrection, and the door into Revelation.